

▽ Ahmose I, limestone statue



1549–1069 BCE

EGYPT NEW KINGDOM

Under Ahmose I – founder of the Eighteenth Dynasty – Egypt was reunified after the expulsion of the Hyksos rulers from the Nile Delta. So began Egypt's most powerful period, the New Kingdom of Egypt, which saw the empire extend into Nubia and western Asia. In keeping with his Theban heritage, Ahmose moved the site of royal tombs from the pyramids to the Valley of the Kings near Thebes.

c. 1650 BCE Northern Egypt
is occupied by invaders from the Levant, the Hyksos, the first foreign rulers of Egypt

c. 1600 BCE A catastrophic volcanic eruption on Thera (Santorini) triggers the decline of the Minoan civilization

1500 BCE

c. 1600 BCE Global climate
begins to cool, possibly as a result of volcanic eruptions around the world

1595–1530 BCE The Hittites and Kassites use iron weapons and horse-drawn chariots in their invasion of Babylon



**c. 1810–1750 BCE
KING HAMMURABI**

Now remembered for introducing his eponymous Babylonian law code, Hammurabi was revered in his own time for expanding the Babylonian Empire across almost all of Mesopotamia.



◁ Oracle bone from Shang dynasty

c. 1600 BCE

SHANG DYNASTY ESTABLISHED

After the semi-mythical Xia Dynasty, the Yellow River valley was ruled by the first Chinese kings for whom there is firm evidence – the Shang Dynasty. It was founded by Chen Tang, victor of the Battle of Mingtiao against the Xia. Artefacts made from bronze, jade, and ceramic, and oracle bones (bones inscribed with characters and used for divination) attest to the cultural sophistication of the Shang.